

next summer. There are some jobs that are just too taxing—even for 5,000 bucks.

The next summer, I opened up the Saturday-morning paper and saw the following ad: “Bricklayer needed. Must have previous experience. \$12/hr.” Twelve dollars an hour! Wow! (This was in the 1970s, and I was still a teen, so this sounded great to me.) There was only one problem: I had never so much as touched a brick in my life. So what did I do? I lied and said I had previous experience (never, ever a good idea). I showed up on the first day without the faintest idea of how to do anything. I couldn’t even mix my own mortar, let alone put it on a trowel and lay down a brick. And these weren’t the small bricks you see in nice suburban houses. These were gigantic cinderblocks for industrial buildings. I was in over my head.

Luckily for me, the foreman decided to let me stay, despite my now-obvious lies about being experienced. For the first week, he demoted me from “bricklayer” to “cinderblock carrier” and paid me a lot less. (See? Lying didn’t pay off.) I’d lug bricks back and forth between the men on-site who actually knew what they were doing. During the foreman’s lunch break, he took it upon himself to train me in the art of laying bricks. After one week, I picked up the basic skill set. After two weeks, my walls were mostly straight. I can’t tell you how many shirts I ruined on the job. It was hard work building walls made of 30-pound bricks. The sun was beating down on me every hour of every day, and I had to take salt pills to stay hydrated. A couple of the guys on my team were hospitalized for heat stroke. At the end of the day, I was so exhausted I could hardly walk straight. I don’t think I’ve ever slept as well as I did after a day of bricklaying. I laid bricks for the rest of the summer and came back the next summer, too, because by then I wasn’t lying about having previous experience.

And those weren’t even the worst jobs I’ve done! I spent one summer hanging off the side of a building, strapped into a harness, stripping the plywood off cement after it had solidified. There was debris flying around up there—sharp nails and pieces of drywall. It was insanely dangerous, which is why it paid so well. But by far the